While this is happening, English cricket is fast undergoing a flexing of its muscles under Duncan Fletcher and Michael Vaughan. Fletcher is obsessed with his seam attack being very quick. He thinks, not without reason, that the difference at the highest level, and the way England will finally frighten sides, is to have a pack of very quick bowlers. I am bowling close to 90 miles an hour regularly. They want to find another five miles an hour of speed from me. So, between this philosophy and the fear about the contortion in my back, I start trying to change my action behind the scenes with England. They use examples of bowlers that bowl very naturally quick and we try to build parts of them into me. Brett Lee and Shoaib Akhtar were amongst the two quickest – and certainly most feared – fast bowlers then. I had found that out first-hand. They both have a longer run-up so the staff ask me to lengthen mine. To bowl really, really quick, they tell me, you need to have a long run-up. Other small components are thrown into the air too. I'm asked to try all number of different things. Brett Lee, they say, loads up with his front arm much lower, meaning he can get extra speed and he is not contorting his body as much, putting less pressure on his back.

I am never really comfortable with any of the requests. My rhythm is upset. I feel unnatural and unsettled. Bowling is turned from something that was once the most effortless and natural thing in the world into a sort of checklist, an exam to pass. I am told that it will work in time, that it will feel strange in the short term but long term, it will reap rewards. I nod and agree. I don't want to make a fuss. I want to get quicker. I lose sight and memory of those euphoric visions of looking back up and seeing batters move inside out, that essence of the ball moving late like a laser beam. I forget what I am trying to do at all. Just try and get faster, I'm telling myself. That's what they want, speed. And keep the arm low, the run-up long, the back straight. Everything is off-kilter. When I play one Test on tour in South Africa, I keep bowling short and wide to Herschelle Gibbs. I know that short and wide is the worst place to bowl to any batter really, let alone Gibbs. I get two wickets in the game, both from short and wide deliveries that are hit to third man. I'm too embarrassed to celebrate them. Gibbs, meanwhile, keeps pulling and cutting me for six. My action is a mix of lots of component parts of different opinions now, my head a collection of analogies, scientific maps and explanations. What's worse, the one place I want to be, the place I am safe, the space I have made the world open up